Critical Making Worksheet

Slides: glennritchey.net/tandt/diss-design/slides **Worksheet:** glennritchey.net/tandt/diss-design/worksheet

Critical Making as Research Method

Critical making uses material, hands-on work with technologies to extend critical reflection. Matt Ratto defines it as the effort "to use material forms of engagement with technologies to supplement and extend critical reflection and, in doing so, to reconnect our lived experiences with technologies to social and conceptual critique" (Ratto 253). The knowledge comes through the process and not the product alone.

In what fields is critical making used?

- Science and technology studies and information studies (Ratto); engineering pedagogy (Mann); digital humanities, and pedagogy (Johnson & Salter; Smithies)

How it works

Gather the concepts. Review the relevant literature and name the concepts and questions the making will work through.
Build prototypes. Design and build technical prototypes. Function matters less than what the building teaches.
Reconfigure and reflect. Rework the prototypes, discuss what they show, and carry that back to the concepts.
Paraphrased from Ratto (2011)

Strengths	Limitations
• Connects lived experience with technology to critique • Makes abstract claims about technology concrete and testable	• The mapping of theory onto technology can turn reductive (Ratto 257) • The purpose can look opaque to colleagues (Smithies)

Key considerations for researchers

Positionality (Mann); Shared authority; Visible steps; Maintenance; Platform dependence (Smithies).

How critical making compares to other making methods

Method	Central question	How it differs from critical making
Research through design	What can designing this artifact teach us?	Aims at design knowledge and better artifacts; critique of technology is not required
Speculative design	What futures could this object provoke us to imagine?	Objects provoke an audience, often as exhibits; making is less a site of the maker's own learning
Participatory design	How can the people affected shape the system?	Centers stakeholder decision-making in a system's design; reflection is a means rather than the end
Maker / DIY culture	Can I build or fix this myself?	Making as skill, hobby, or self-reliance; critique is optional (Mann's "do it together" pushes it toward critique)

How I plan to use critical making in my dissertation

I am integrating my critical making practice into digital literacy by developing “distant making”: an insider steps back from an archive they know closely and makes something new from the whole, using processes they can see into. My distance is a matter of choice.

Example studies using critical making

Ratto (2011): flwr. Participants built networked “flwrs” set to a gift economy. When most of them only listened, the network “died,” and the discussion turned to reciprocity.

Mann (2014): maktivism. Students hack dumpster computers and ID readers. The “Griefcase” makes a guard who wants to search it give up his own fingerprints.

Smithies (2017): Full Stack DH. A personal research environment on a Raspberry Pi: control of the whole stack, yet still dependent on Amazon, and still needing care.

Johnson & Salter (2025): “Generation.” Students regenerate their own assignments with ChatGPT and critique the output.

Discussion questions

1. What could you make, instead of write, that would test a claim in your own research? What might the making show that the writing can't?

2. Kamĩrĩĩthũ let a community make from its own archive. Who are the insiders to the materials you study, and what would change if they did the making instead of you?

3. Flores used a corporate tool to build something that doesn't depend on corporate tools. Where is your line between using a platform and depending on it, and what do you owe your readers about a process you can't fully see into?

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